



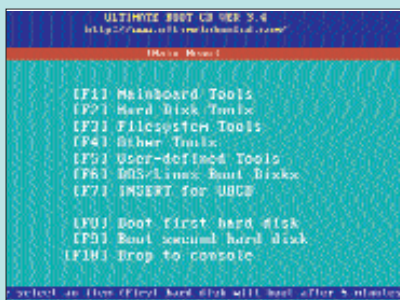
The Ultimate Boot CD Experience

One CD, lots of tools—indispensable!

Jayesh Limaye

Find on this month's *Utilities* CD the Ultimate Boot CD (UBCD) from www.ultimatebootcd.com. This is a bootable CD based on Linux. It contains a host of precious tools and utilities which everyone in general and computer hardware professionals in particular will find useful—something like a doctor's first-aid kit!

UBCD contains tools that let you service and maintain your computer: tools that let you diagnose computer problems, and tools that let you repair them. You can boot from this CD even if you aren't able to boot from your computer due to a hard drive failure—you can then run diagnostic programs to



The UBCD welcome screen

check the disk.

Burn the UBCD image on the *Utilities* CD to CD, then set the affected computer to boot from the CD. Insert the UBCD into the drive, and you'll be booting via UBCD. Keep in mind that you'll need a hard drive with a larger capacity than the amount of data to be recovered. In the main menu, you'll see many options such as Mainboard Tools, Hard Disk Tools, Filesystem Tools, Other Tools, DOS/Linux Boot Disks, INSERT for UBCD, and more. Each option is preceded by a function key, which is the hotkey to launch that particular option. There are many utilities, so we'll mention a few to get you started.

Mainboard Tools

Pressing [F1] will take you to the Mainboard tools. There are DOS-based (as is the case with most of the utilities on UBCD) diagnostic and benchmark tools that provide you information about the various components of the motherboard, CPU, memory, peripherals, and so forth.

Notable are utilities such as !BIOS, CMO-SPWD, and WipeCMOS. The latter can reset the CMOS password if you forget it and get locked out!

Hard Disk Tools

Press [F2] to enter Hard Disk Tools. You'll be able to view diagnostic tools for various hard drive brands. Press the right arrow key twice to go to the third page of

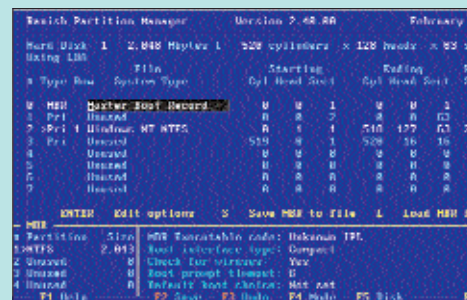


The Salvation HDD Scan & Repair tool

Hard Disk Tools. Here, under the "Others" section, you will be able to view Salvation HDD Scan & Repair V3.0. This tool lets you recover a failed hard drive. It is a generic tool, so it works with all hard drive brands. Press [F4] to launch the application. Default Scan will scan the entire hard drive for recoverable data. This would be the option most users select. Advanced Scan is for experts; here, one can choose the starting point as well as the end point (in percentage) for the scan.

Filesystem Tools

Here, you can find many disk partitioning utilities, boot managers, File Tools, and NTFS tools. Notable is Ranish Partition Manager, a very easy-to-use menu-driven disk partitioning utility. There are a host of utilities under File Tools, which let you browse the con-



The Ranish Partition Manager

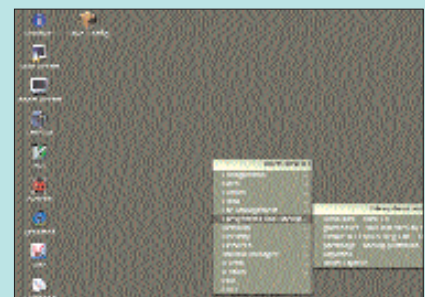
tents of the hard drive in DOS mode. System administrators and computer service professionals will be delighted to find the offline NT Password & Registry Editor, which lets one recover passwords for Windows systems such as 2000 and XP. You can even edit the Registry from outside Windows. Active NTFS Reader and NTFS4DOS lets you view the contents of NTFS drives, something not possible using regular DOS boot disks.

Other Tools

If your hard drive is infected by a virus, you can choose from amongst F-Prot, McAfee, AVG, and Avast! to fix your problem. Similarly, there are network related utilities and browsers, most of which are beyond the scope of utility of the home user.

DOS / Linux Boot Disks

There are four DOS boot disks and four for Linux, all crammed with utilities. A boot disk simulates booting from a floppy using the floppy's image on the UBCD.



INSERT for UBCD

"INSERT" for UBCD

If your hard drive does not boot and you're not comfortable with the DOS screen, you can boot into INSERT, a version of Linux that runs off the UBCD. It has many cool utilities, and it sports a GUI. You can use it to diagnose problems and also repair them.

That's Not All!

UBCD is customisable. You can add your own programs to make it more interesting and useful—for example, you can add your own floppy images. Find more information about this at www.ultimatebootcd.com/customize.html. ■

jayesh_limaye@thinkdigit.com